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Queerness Made Visible: How Victorian Poets Disguised Queerness

Victorian society was very strict about gender roles, sexuality, and morality. This made it difficult to openly express same-sex desire. Queer relationships were not something that was usually spoken about directly and they were often treated as something “unspeakable,” which means that they had to be discreet and hide their relationships or desires. Instead of disappearing, queer desire showed up in indirect and coded ways, especially in literature.

This pressure is reflected in queer Victorian poetry as poets were able to find creative ways to express their desires while still following social rules. Since they could not openly discuss queer themes, they used different strategies to disguise it. These include showing deep emotional bonds between men, using metaphor and physical intimacy to suggest desire, and placing queer relationships in a different setting where they would feel less controversial.

The tension between being able to express yourself and having to hide who you are is especially visible in Alexander Smith’s *A Life-Drama* (1853), particularly in “Forerunners,” Christina Rossetti’s *Goblin Market* (1859), and Michael Field’s *Long Ago* (1889), especially in “Adown the Lesbian vales.” Each of these pieces show strong emotional connections, as well as physical, that challenge the norms of Victorian societal expectations. However, each of these stories hides their queerness in different ways.

In this essay, its focus will be arguing that Alexander Smith, Christina Rossetti, and Michael Field all disguise queer desire through literary strategies, but they differ in how they manage this. Smith does this through showing a deep emotional bond between two men and redirects it within something socially acceptable. Rossetti uses metaphor, physical intimacy, and a moral framework to disguise queer desire. Field takes an entirely different approach and by avoiding Victorian society and expressing queer desire in a society where it can exist more freely.

For cultural context, Victorian society was deeply invested in controlling what could and could not be spoken of, especially when it came to taboo topics like sexuality. One of the most important concepts for understanding this cultural setting is what is described as “the unspeakable.” This term is used to refer to things that were not to be said, as well as things that are socially unacceptable, such as same-sex attraction (McGuire 44). Even when queer men were on trial for homosexual acts, the term “homosexual was avoided and replaced with words like “unnatural” and “infamous.” This was done in an attempt to stop queerness from spreading. Something important mentioned in this text is that the censorship of queerness did not get rid of it, but instead created “other, richer languages of description” (McGuire 45). This means that instead of disappearing, queer desire was expressed in indirect ways, such as metaphor, coded language, and imagery. Since people could not speak openly about same-sex relationships, they found alternative ways to represent those feelings. As a result, poetry created by queer Victorian poets often have encoded forms of queerness that must be read carefully in order to be fully understood.

This cultural context helps to explain why Victorian poets had to rely on disguise as their same-sex desire could not be shared with the outside world. Instead, their desires became

something that could appear on page after being translated into safer words and forms. In this way, the disguise was not just a limitation but also a creative strategy that allowed poets to express what could not be openly said while still staying within the boundaries of Victorian society.

In Alexander Smith's *A-Life Drama* (1853), queer desire is expressed through intense connections between men. However, it is carefully framed to make it feel socially acceptable. Smith's background helps to explain why his poetry often focuses on emotional expression and unconventional relationships. Born in 1829 into a working-class Scottish family, he left school at only eleven years old to work in a textile factory with his father. Later, he educated himself in literature and became published in working-class journals before becoming successful in the literary field (Clapp-Itnyre, Queer Track #1). This background helps to explain why his poetry is deeply emotional while putting less emphasis on strict structures. Instead, he has chosen to prioritize feelings and connections.

In *A Life-Drama*, this is this pattern becomes clear through the way Smith develops emotional and physical closeness between men while framing it as artistic connection. This pattern is mostly seen in "Forerunners." In this poem, the speaker uses deeply intimate language to describe another man. This is seen in the quote, "He was the sun, I was that squab—the earth / And bask'd me in his light until he drew" (Alexander lines 10-11). This is a metaphor that positions the man the speaker is describing as something that provides light and life to him. This speaker is not simply admiring this man but is depending on him for sustenance. This is intensified by the next lines that say, "And I rejoiced upon his shore of pearls / A weak enamor'd sea" (Alexander lines 13-14). These lines portray the speaker as overwhelmed and drawn toward the other man, much like the tide is pulled toward the shore.

In this section, the word “enamor’d” is important as it is usually used to describe romantic or emotional attraction. Smith could have chosen to describe this relationship as one of mentorship or admiration, but instead he uses language that suggests longing and attachment. In that choice, he is showing that queerness is present, even if it is not directly stated.

This idea continues in moments of physical interaction, such as when the speaker says, “He grasp’d my hand, — I look’d upon his face, — / A thought struck all the blood into his cheeks / Like a strong buffet. His great flashing eyes / Burn’d on mine own” (Smith, lines 45–48). This scene is emphasizing touch and keeping eye contact, which are often associated with romantic or emotional intensity. However, because the interaction occurs within a discussion of poetry and artistic ambition, it is again redirected into a safer, more socially acceptable form.

Through these choices, Smith is presenting queer desire as something that is felt deeply while still being carefully hidden within poetic expression. This reflects the Victorian cultural idea of the “unspeakable,” where same-sex desire could not be openly discussed and instead had to be expressed indirectly through coded language and emotional intensity rather than active acknowledgment.

While Smith hides queer desire within male artistic relationships, Christina Rossetti’s *Goblin Market* (1862) highlights a complex example of disguised queerness in Victorian poetry as she uses metaphor and intense physical intimacy between women to express desire that cannot be directly discussed. Rossetti’s history helps to explain this indirect approach. Born in 1830 into a well-known family of artists, she was deeply influenced by religion and the High-Church tradition. She had a strong commitment to moral and spiritual values that led her to never get married, despite multiple proposals, which likely aids in queer interpretations of her work (Clapp-Itnyre, Queer Track #2). This tension between religious devotion and emotional intensity

has a strong impact on *Goblin Market* as desire is expressed but contained within Rossetti's moral boundaries.

In *Goblin Market*, Rossetti presents a poem that originally feels like a moral cautionary tale about temptation and redemption, but it carefully disguises queer desire within the relationship between Laura and Lizzie by displaying their intimacy in a socially acceptable way. While the poem seems to focus on warning against being unable to control yourself, its most emotionally intense moments focus on the deep physical and emotional bond between the women over the punishment.

This becomes clear when Lizzie chooses to risk her own life in order to save Laura's life. After Laura becomes unwell after eating the fruit, Lizzie walks straight into danger by going to the goblins who hurt Laura and allows herself to suffer their violence if it means helping Laura. In the poem, it says, "Claw'd with their nails / Barking, mewling, hissing, mocking / Tore her gown and soil'd her stocking... / Held her hands and squeez'd their fruits / Against her mouth to make her eat" (Rossetti lines 401-403;406-407). This scene highlights not only Lizzie's physical suffering and can be read as an act of sexual violence.

However, Lizzie does not back down. Shortly after this, it says, "Though the goblins cuff'd and caught her... / Would not open lip from lip / Lest they should cram a mouthful in" (Rossetti lines 424; 431-432). Her refusal to open her mouth becomes a powerful statement of bodily autonomy. Even while being attacked, she maintains control over her own body, resisting the goblins' attempts to force "the fruit" upon her and receiving the cure to save Laura.

Her resistance to the goblin's violence and losing her bodily autonomy is important when Lizzie returns to save Laura. This is because Lizzie is no longer controlled by them, meaning that

she can choose how her body is used. In an act of regaining her autonomy, she offers herself willingly to Laura, becoming the source of healing rather than a victim of coercion. When she tells Laura to “Come and kiss me / Never mind my bruises / Hug me, kiss me, suck my juices,” she is shifting the moment from one of forced contact to one of chosen intimacy (Rossetti lines 466-468). Lizzie’s body, once under threat, is now something she willingly shares. This transforms the earlier violence they have experienced into an act of care, closeness, and emotional connection between the women.

Despite the seemingly clear queerness of this exchange, Rossetti hides the queer aspects behind the guise of “sisterhood.” Throughout this poem, Lizzie and Laura are referred to as “sister,” including in the scene above. This is evident as it says, “She clung about her sister” (Rossetti line 485). However, this line is followed up with, “Kiss'd and kiss'd and kiss'd her / She kiss'd and kiss'd her with a hungry mouth” (Rossetti lines 486; 492). The contrast between these lines is important because the label “sister” suggests a socially acceptable, non-romantic relationship, while the repeated kissing and the phrase “hungry mouth” express a level of physical intensity that goes beyond typical familial affection.

This allows for queer desire to be disguised in this poem as calling them “sisters” would have been beneficial in providing Victorian society with a socially acceptable relationship while still allowing space for a deeper meaning. The emotional and bodily closeness between Laura and Lizzie becomes the center of the poem, but it is framed in a way that avoids direct confrontation with Victorian norms. This reflects the Victorian idea of the “unspeakable.” Not just because it is an example of how queer desire is hidden, but also because it is being used in a socially acceptable way. Instead of being directly expressed, it appears through the language of sisterhood and moral sacrifice, which allows the poem to present intense intimacy between

women without openly challenging Victorian norms.

Michael Field's *Long Ago* (1889) depicts a dramatic shift from the earlier strategies of disguising queerness as it does not attempt to hide the desire but instead relocates it outside of Victorian society altogether. Understanding this approach requires attention to the authors' background. "Michael Field" is the shared pseudonym of Katharine Bradley and Edith Cooper. These two women were not just collaborators, but were also aunt and niece, as well as lovers who wrote together as one poetic voice. They published under a male name to gain respect in a literary culture that often dismissed female writers and to more freely express love for women (Clapp-Itnyre, Queer Track #3).

In addition to this, they were a part of the Aesthetic movement and were inspired by classical Greek literature, particularly Sappho. They embraced "art for art's sake" and drew on ancient settings as a way to distance their work from contemporary moral standards (Clapp-Itnyre, Queer Track #3). This background is crucial because it explains why their poetry does not merely disguise queerness within Victorian society but instead actively avoids that society.

In "Adown the Lesbian vales" from *Long Ago*, it expands this strategy by depicting a community of women who do not shy away from queerness. This poem opens with a scene of communal female activity. This says, "I watch the lovely rout / Of maidens flitting 'mid the honey-bees" (Field lines 3-4). This context is important as it establishes that this is an all-female environment where the presence of men is not seen. The speaker's role within this community is that of both an observer and a participant.

As the poem continues, it uses imagery to emphasize sensory pleasure and intimacy. An example of this is when it says, "So fresh as they / When on my breast / They lean, and say / All that they would" (Field lines 23-26). This scene highlights the physical and emotional closeness

between the women, as the act of leaning on the speaker's body displays the physical and the way they speak to each other freely displays the emotional. This creates a moment where closeness and desire are shown as natural and unrestricted. This can be compared to the way intimacy is portrayed in *Goblin Market* as this version of intimacy is seen as unproblematic and ordinary, while the intimacy in *Goblin Market* was within the context of temptation, punishment, and redemption.

Even when the poem discusses marriage, it continues to center the relationships between women. In the last stanza, it says, "To that pure band alone / I sing of marriage-loves" (Field lines 28-29). This shows that marriage is not depicted as a heterosexual institution like it would have been in the Victorian era. Instead, it is something that is understood and performed inside of this community of women. Shortly after this, it says, "No girls let fall / Their maiden zone / At Hymen's call" (Field lines 32-34). These lines are interesting as they suggest that even traditional structures have been reimagined in this community through a female-centered perspective.

This poem's depiction of queerness was made possible due to how it has separated itself from the Victorian setting and their values, placing it in ancient Greece instead. This allowed Field to avoid the strictness of Victorian society that made queer desire "unspeakable" as they created a setting where queerness is seen as normal. This reflects the cultural idea of the "unspeakable" in a different way than Smith or Rossetti, because instead of disguising queer desire within Victorian principles, Field avoids those principles all together. In doing this, the poem shows that queer desire does not need to be hidden. In fact, it only becomes "unspeakable" when it is placed within restrictive social conditions, like those of Victorian society.

When viewed together, Alexander Smith, Christina Rossetti, and Michael Field all show that queer desire was a real thing within Victorian literature and society, but they respond to its

presence different ways. Smith disguises queerness by placing queer desire within strong male friendships and emotional connections that feel socially acceptable when viewed on the surface level. Similarly, Rossetti disguises queer desire by using metaphor, physical intimacy, and the "sisterhood" to disguise desire in a way that appears moral and acceptable to Victorian standards. Going in a different direction as Smith and Rossetti, Field chose to express queer desire more openly by placing it in distant historical and mythic setting that allowed queerness to be explored with less immediate social risk within Victorian society.

These differences matter as they show that queer desire was not absent from Victorian literature but instead required different strategies in order to be expressed safely within the era they were living in. Ultimately, these poets are not simply hiding queerness. They are revealing how Victorian poetry became a safe space when queer desire could survive by changing its language, form, and setting.

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